be over and above the normal day's routine. Since I was under restrictions, there was no question of going home during the mid-term. Whatever spare time that I had during the mid-term break, I would go to the squadron anteroom to listen to some music. One afternoon, the Squadron Commander walked in while on his rounds and on seeing me, asked why I had not gone home on mid-term. I was quite taken aback since he was the one who had awarded me the restrictions just a couple of days earlier. When I explained why, he said never mind, I know you're not at fault and that notwithstanding my punishment status, I could proceed on mid-term leave for the balance of the days. In a flash, I was up and away and by evening, at my home in Anand Park.

When the term recommenced, the DivO obviously came to know that I had somehow managed to still go home. He really got after me as he felt I had somehow beaten the system. In no time at all, I had raked in twenty-eight more restrictions; fourteen for going on mid-term break without permission, and fourteen for not doing restrictions during the break. It was a double-whammy. At a total of forty-two restrictions in a single term, I was now in the category of incorrigible cadets, liable for relegation on disciplinary grounds. As part of the process, I was marched up to the Deputy Commandant, Air Commodore PD Dogra, for a final review, before going in front of the Commandant. Fortunately for me, the Deputy Commandant took a more balanced view and let me off with a stern warning. Perhaps the fact that he knew my father from his Air Force days played a crucial part in the matter. I was fortunate not to lose a term just because of misunderstandings but nevertheless learnt a crucial lesson of how to keep one's counsel and see the long game.

Academics was not my strong point, but I never let it get to me and I had some fun with my best friend Shaminder Kumar

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